

Why Fico lost his Brussels bite

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-08-20 13:59

【メール原文】

POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By MAX GRIERA DOBRÉ RANÓ!

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DOBRÉ RANÓ! Welcome to Day 4 of Playbook on the road. I'm Max Grier, survivor of Bratislava's central station, which is in dire need of a revamp. Tomorrow we head to Budapest ... train delays allowing ;).

In today's Playbook:

- Why Robert Fico has gone quiet in Brussels — and how Slovakia's opposition plans to challenge him at home.
- Brussels is doing what Brussels does best: updating LinkedIn.
- Faces in the crowd: Michal Šimečka, Prince Laurent of Belgium, Aliénor Margerit, Péter Magyar, Martin Hojsík, Mykhailo Fedorov, Masai Russell, Raphaël Glucksmann, Wendy Van Wanten and more ...

DRIVING THE DAY

NO FIGHT FROM FICO: When Viktor Orbán was voted out in Hungary, Brussels feared that Slovakia's Prime Minister Robert Fico would be the next EU disrupter-in-chief . Four months on, Fico has largely fallen into line, backing sanctions on Russia and allowing Ukraine's talks on joining the EU to advance.

"Mr. Fico was hiding behind Mr. Orbán, and now he can no longer do that," Michal Šimečka, leader of the centrist opposition Progressive Slovakia party, told me in an interview in his minimalist Bratislava office, Birkenstocks on the floor under his desk.

Progressive Slovakia leads the polls a year out from a general election, at 20 percent, but the party may struggle to form a majority because Šimečka, a former MEP, has ruled out working with any of Fico's current coalition partners. An opposition-only coalition would need to be so broad to reach a majority that it would be chaotic to manage, according to POLITICO's Poll of Polls .

Šimečka blasted what he described as Fico's "hypocrisy," saying the prime minister is still "criticizing the [EU] sanctions in Slovakia ... but then he supports all those" in Brussels, referring to the bloc's restrictions on Russia. Fico has had few tangible gains from his "sovereignist" foreign policy, Šimečka argued, only "reputational damage" that "drifts us into isolation."

Money leash: Fico, whose office did not reply to a request for comment, has reason not to push Brussels too far, as billions in EU funds are at stake. In May, the European Parliament urged the Commission to trigger a rule-of-law mechanism that could freeze EU cash to Slovakia, citing the dismantling of anti-corruption bodies, weaker graft laws and eroding press freedom.

The Commission has so far not frozen any funds. A Commission spokesperson said there are ongoing regular assessments with Slovak authorities about protecting the EU budget. In its Rule of Law Report published last month, the Commission flagged problems including weak anti-corruption enforcement and threats to media independence.

One reason for the Commission to avoid angering Fico: Relative calm has settled around the European Council table since Orbán's departure, at least until next year's French election. Apart from the Slovak leader, other populists like Czechia's Andrej Babiš and Bulgaria's Rumen Radev have also pursued a more pragmatic relationship with Brussels, two EU diplomats granted anonymity to speak frankly told my colleague Gabriel Gavin.

Šimečka accused Fico's government of mishandling EU funds and changing laws in ways that benefit his political allies, pointing to the dismantling of two anti-corruption bodies that dealt with high-profile cases. (Fico and his allies have defended the reforms as a response to past abuses and bias in the justice system and attacked scrutiny of Slovakia's spending of EU funds as politically motivated.)

Yet Šimečka argued that Slovakia remains far from pre-election Hungary, which was in "a much darker place." One check on power: The Constitutional Court "is working," Šimečka said, as last year it effectively blocked the abolition of the whistleblower protection office and struck down key restrictions the government wanted to impose on NGOs.

Šimečka has himself faced questions: Police are investigating alleged financial irregularities at an NGO run by his mother, including a €5,000 payment to Šimečka that he says was repayment of a loan but which appeared in subsidy accounts as an expense. Šimečka acknowledged "mismanagement at the NGO" but insisted the case has "nothing to do with me or my party" and that police should determine responsibility.

The Magyar playbook: Šimečka's strategy ahead of the election year — like Hungary's Péter Magyar did with Orbán — is to hammer Fico's economic record rather than fight culture wars. He argues that Fico has left Slovakia poorer and trailing its neighbors, with worse infrastructure than Poland or Czechia. Šimečka said he's not yet in touch with Magyar but that he will reach out because "its very important that we have a communication channel and a good dialogue between us, especially as the election year comes closer."

Šimečka expects "echoes" of Hungary's election campaign, which featured disinformation and personal attacks. But he believes Fico's "shameless ability to stir up hatred and fear," including his anti-Brussels rhetoric, is losing steam and will fail on election day — "as it failed to work in the case of Viktor Orbán in Hungary."

BIG AND BREAKING

A SOFTER TOUCH ON TECH: The Commission is changing gear on Big Tech, shifting focus from blockbuster fines to compliance — but critics are questioning whether quieter enforcement is the right approach, Jacob Parry writes.

UKRAINE'S ELECTION ROW: Ukrainian politicians from across the spectrum have slapped down ousted Defense Minister Mykhailo Fedorov's demand for wartime elections, saying it would sow division and play into Russia's hands, Veronika Melkozerova reports from Kyiv.

"ECONOMIC D-DAY": Donald Trump posted on Truth Social overnight that he'd unleash the "MOST CRUSHING ECONOMIC OPERATION EVER TAKEN AGAINST ANY COUNTRY" to break the deadlock with Iran, along with sanctions on countries that help Tehran ... though, as my colleagues reported Tuesday , former U.S. officials and Iran experts are skeptical that turning the economic screws will persuade Tehran to end the war on Washington's terms.

FRANCE'S CLIMATE BILL: France faces up to €15 billion in costs from a summer of extreme heat and wildfires — just as Paris is struggling to cut its deficit, service €3.5 trillion in debt and boost defense spending, Victor Goury-Laffont reports.

DRONES TAKE TO THE FARM: Brussels wants to lift its long-standing ban on spraying pesticides by drone , Ketrin Johecová explains.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

NEW ENVOY IN PARIS: Aliénor Margerit has been appointed head of the European Commission's representation in France, taking on the task of bridging Paris and Brussels as France heads toward a potentially seismic 2027 presidential election.

SPEAKING OF WHICH: My colleagues in Paris have more on MEP Raphaël Glucksmann's center-left bid for the presidency, which he's expected to confirm in a prime-time TV interview on Sunday.

SOUTH KOREA SNUB: Donald Trump's move to cut joint military exercises with South Korea and his push for a meeting with Kim Jong Un have rattled Washington's allies in Asia . Now they're looking to each other for security.

BRITAIN'S SUBMARINE TOWN: The English port town gearing up to build the U.K.'s AUKUS fleet has endured decades of underinvestment in housing, skills and public services.

NOT IMPRESSED: British voters were underwhelmed by Prime Minister Andy Burnham's response to the drought and wildfires that have hit the country this summer, according to polling written up by Tim Ross and Abby Wallace .

BRATISLAVA CORNER

AN MEP'S WEDDING VENUE: Tucked down an unassuming street near the presidential palace here in Bratislava is Cafe Next Apache, a cozy, yellow-lit bar in an old parish house, with a leafy courtyard for drinking or working. European Parliament Vice President Martin Hojsík recommended it to me, saying he is a regular — and even held his wedding reception here.

When I arrive, waitress and journalism student Gretka Greslik recommends that I eat oškvarkové pagáče, a savory pastry with pieces of bacon. Across the courtyard, she tells me, there's still a chapel, and every Sunday people get together for drinks after the service.

MODERN ART ON THE WATER: A 25-minute drive away, the Danubiana Meulensteen Art Museum sits on a small island in the Danube, with glass walls and high ceilings. Opened in 2000 by a Dutch art collector, it makes for a peaceful escape to admire more than 200 sculptures and paintings by Slovak and international artists.

WHERE TO SWIM: Bratislava has plenty of lakes within easy reach by public transport. Veľký Draždiak is one of the most accessible, though it has a more urban feel, surrounded by housing. For something wilder and less crowded, head to Rusovské jazero.

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BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals with some showers expected. High 21C.

A NEW PRINCE: The latest addition to Belgium's royal family arrived in classic Belgian fashion — via an administrative procedure at a town hall. Prince Laurent, brother of King Philippe, officially recognized Clément Vandenkerckhove as his son in front of a civil registrar in February, *Soir Mag* reported .

Vandenkerckhove, 26, was born out of Laurent's relationship with Flemish singer Wendy Van Wanten, but the prince only publicly accepted him as his son last year. With the formal recognition, Vandenkerckhove is now his father's heir and can take his last name, de Saxe-Cobourg — though he won't be in line for the throne.

NOT A MASS HIRING: If your LinkedIn feed suddenly seems full of people "happy to announce" they've passed an EU selection test, don't panic: the Berlaymont hasn't embarked on a late-summer hiring spree. The results of the latest CAST (Contract Agent Selection Tool) session are out — and Brussels is doing what Brussels does best: updating LinkedIn.

Open CAST-ing: CAST tests are the gateway to becoming a contract agent in the EU institutions. "Anybody can register in the CAST database at any time," an EPSO official told *Playbook*, explaining how it all works. "If EU institutions shortlist candidates from the database, EPSO invites them to one of the test sessions, which take place up to 10 times a year." The next sessions will take place in October and November.

Why your feed is flooded: Results from the final CAST session before the summer break landed at the beginning of this week. It's traditionally a popular one among the Parliament's Schuman trainees and Commission's Blue Book trainee crowd, hence the sudden outbreak of celebratory posts.

Not just bragging: Passing CAST doesn't mean you've landed an EU job. It means you're now eligible to be recruited as a contract agent — for jobs typically lasting for three or four years, with a six-year ceiling across the institutions. What makes broadcasting the news rather useful is that former bosses, colleagues and potential hiring managers now know you're available.

So you passed. Now what? Keep refreshing EU Careers — and, this being Brussels, work that network: Knowing which vacancies are about to open can be half the battle. "CAST results stay valid for 10 years," the EPSO official said.

FROM BIRMINGHAM TO BRUSSELS: The European Athletics Championships in the U.K. wrapped up Sunday, but some of its biggest stars are Brussels-bound. Olympic 100-meter hurdles champion Masai Russell and high jumper Gianmarco Tamberi — a crowd favorite fresh from claiming his fourth European title, and third in a row — were confirmed yesterday for the 50th edition of the Memorial Van Damme event in two weeks. Tickets are still available.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: German lawmakers may have to pay into the controversial new pension system — but there'll be an uproar if they get a pay raise to make up for it.

Paris: Jean-Luc Mélenchon will use La France Insoumise's big summer gathering to jump-start his presidential campaign and cement his hold on the French left.

London: Andy Burnham says he's cracking down on the organized crime gangs behind illegal waste dumping.

Washington: Progressive Democrats are heading to the Panamerican Congress in Uruguay determined to show not all of Washington buys into Donald Trump's "Donroe Doctrine."

Canberra: The vibe is relief as the sitting season wraps up after a truly bipartisan week.

AGENDA

— The Political and Security Committee meets at 2 p.m.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Catherine Griset; Brunswick's Jonathan Faull; Portuguese politician Augusto Santos Silva; POLITICO's Sanya Khetani-Shah; former Italian Prime Minister Enrico Letta; Petros Fassoulas of European Movement International. State Foundation Day in Hungary.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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